

Neuter Plural Morphology in Romanian: Conservatism in Usage, Innovation in Form

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Abstract

This paper examines the plural morphology of neuter nouns in Romanian in a comparative Romance and Indo-European context. Unlike other Romance languages, which largely collapse neuter plurals into feminine singulars (e.g., Latin *gaudia* → French *joie*), Romanian maintains the neuter as a distinct grammatical category. Moreover, Romanian reanalyzes the neuter in the plural while retaining masculine agreement in the singular, preserving the singular–plural alternation. This represents **soft morphological leveling**: the category is preserved in usage while the plural form is innovatively updated. Vestiges in Western Romance mass nouns, Spanish neuter pronouns, and Ancient Greek collective-to-feminine developments illustrate the historical continuity of these processes.

1. Introduction

Romance languages simplified Latin’s three-gender system, often assimilating neuter plurals into feminine singulars. Western Romance underwent **hard leveling**, losing neuter distinctions formally and functionally. For example, Latin *gaudia* (“joys”) became French *joie* (“joy,” feminine singular). Vestiges remain as **mass or collective interpretations**, e.g., Italian *braccia* (“arms”) or abstract nouns like *beni* (“goods, property”).

Romanian, in contrast, went in the **opposite direction**. Neuter plurals were **reanalyzed in the plural** (modern *-e*), while the singular retains masculine agreement. This preserves the **singular–plural alternation** and functional neuter category while introducing formal innovation—an instance of **soft leveling**. Additional evidence comes from **Spanish neuter pronouns** (*esto, eso*) and **Ancient Greek**, where feminine forms historically arose from neuter collectives through agreement with singular verbs.

2. Historical Background

2.1 Neuter in Latin and Western Romance

Latin neuter plurals like *gaudia* used the suffix *-a*. In French, they were reanalyzed as feminine singulars:

Latin French Gloss

<i>gaudia</i>	<i>joie</i>	“joy”
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Vestiges of neuter loss appear in collective/mass readings:

Language	Example	Notes
Italian	braccia	originally neuter plural; now feminine plural, collective sense
Italian	beni	“goods, property”; neuter plural semantics reflected in collective reading

Spanish retains neuter distinctions in pronouns: *esto* (“this [thing]”), *eso* (“that [thing]”), *aquello* (“that over there”).

2.2 Romanian Divergence

Romanian preserves the neuter category while innovating plural morphology. Historical neuter *-a* became *-e*, creating a plural formally aligned with feminine endings but retaining neuter function. The singular remains masculine:

Latin	Romanian	Gloss
gaudium → gaudia	ou → ouă	“egg”
forum → fora	scaun → scaune	“chair”

3. Data and Observations

3.1 Neuter Plural Usage

Noun	Singular	Plural	Gloss	Notes
ou	un ou	ouă	one egg → eggs	singular masculine, plural neuter distinct
scaun	un scaun	scaune	one chair → chairs	singular masculine, plural neuter distinct

Fully glossed examples

1. *un ou* → *ouă*
 - *un ou* **DET.M.SG egg.M.SG** → *ouă* **egg.N.PL**
 - Singular masculine, plural neuter distinct
2. *un scaun* → *scaune*
 - *un scaun* **DET.M.SG chair.M.SG** → *scaune* **chair.N.PL**

3.2 Morphological Innovation

The plural suffix *-e* is an innovation from historical *-a*. Romanian preserves the **functional neuter category**, echoing Proto-Indo-European patterns where collective endings contributed to gender distinctions.

3.3 Vestiges in Western Romance and Spanish

- **Mass/collective nouns:** Italian *braccia*, *beni* reflect neuter plural semantics.
 - **Spanish neuter pronouns:** *esto*, *eso*, *aquello* show functional neuter remnants.
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3.4 Evidence from Ancient Greek

Ancient Greek shows feminine emerging historically from neuter collectives. Neuter nominative plural nouns, often collective or abstract, agreed with singular verbs, eventually giving rise to feminine morphology. This parallels the **collective** → **gender derivation** seen in Proto-Indo-European and supports the typological plausibility of Romanian’s development.

4. Comparative Analysis: Soft vs. Hard Leveling

Feature	Romanian	Western Romance
Neuter usage	Functionally distinct	Collapsed into feminine/masc
Singular–plural alternation	Preserved	Lost
Neuter plural ending	-e (innovative)	Absorbed/feminized
Morphological conservatism	Preserved category	Lost
Collective/mass semantics	Rare	Often emergent
Historical echo of PIE	Yes	Largely obscured

5. Typological and Historical Implications

1. **Conservative in usage:** Romanian preserves the neuter category and singular–plural alternation.
 2. **Innovative in form:** the plural suffix *-e* updates neuter morphology without collapsing the category.
 3. **Opposite-direction change:** Romanian reanalyzes neuter in the plural, maintaining masculine singular.
 4. **Vestiges in other Romance languages:** mass/collective readings, Spanish neuter pronouns.
 5. **Echo of PIE and Ancient Greek:** neuter collectives historically contribute to feminine formation; Romanian shows a comparable process.
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6. Conclusion

Romanian neuter plurals exemplify **conservatism in usage** with **innovation in plural form**. By reanalyzing the neuter in the plural while keeping masculine agreement in the singular, Romanian preserves the singular–plural alternation lost in Western Romance (e.g., French *joie* from Latin *gaudia*). Vestiges in mass nouns, Spanish neuter pronouns, and parallels in Ancient Greek support the historical and typological relevance of this pattern.

References

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